



Manđu Macú <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>

Writing Assignment2 messages

Max Richter <Max@good.org>

Mon, Sep 15, 2025 at 10:53 AM

To: "thenegativespace3m@gmail.com" <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>

Hi Matzu,

I'm happy to help you with this. What's the timeline for your assignment?

Thanks,

Pastor Max

Max Richter <Max@good.org>

Wed, Sep 17, 2025 at 6:35 PM

To: "thenegativespace3m@gmail.com" <thenegativespace3m@gmail.com>

Hi Matzu,

Checking back with you on your assignment timeline.

Here's some initial thoughts:

- What got you into the pastorship?

I had a very positive experience at church leadership camp in high school at Lake Poinsett near Arlington, SD. I grew up about 45 minutes from there in Madison.

I was so impressed with the adult leaders and friends I made from around the state that I wanted to be part of a leadership role. Friends convinced me to run for office on the district and statewide youth councils and it was a life changing experience for me. I felt God's unconditional love and acceptance of me in a deeper way than I had ever felt before. I came home from camp and told my parents I wanted to be a pastor.

This call continued to persist into college with student leadership roles that I had in new student orientation, and I wondered if I would want to be a dean of students. The call to local church ministry continued to persist though. I spoke with my home church's pastor who told me that many people had been praying that I would come to ask him about ordained ministry.

I spent a few years in full time youth and children's ministry and served in therapeutic recreation for seniors as well as I made certain I wanted to continue with this calling. One morning I got called in to sub for a worship service when the chaplain was sick. One the residents approached me afterward and said, "you know you're in the wrong job, don't you?" She encouraged me to do whatever it took to pursue seminary.

I have found pastoral ministry to be profoundly rewarding for 26 years now.

- What does a day-to-day-by-day look like, particularly, in the buildup to a worship service?

We plan months in advance with worship themes, hymn selection and seasonal special services such as Advent/Christmas, Lent and Easter. Coordinating with staff on all these, both in the office and with our various musical ensembles is very important to make sure things run smoothly. Caring for weekly details such as the liturgy, and various audio visual needs, along with announcements are all part of creating a cohesive and smooth flowing service.

There are lots of other responsibilities as a pastor with weddings and funerals, staff supervision, leadership development, strategic planning, connecting with the community, welcoming new visitors, stewardship, working with colleague groups for support and sharing leadership as fellow clergy. This list is not exhaustive but gives you some ideas of the variety of daily activities.

- What goes into writing a sermon?

We want to help people connect with God through the ancient scriptures and modern-day life with a call to action. Studying various commentaries on scripture to help with interpretation, responding to the current events of the world and creating an inclusive and welcoming community are all on-going practices that inform both sermon writing and worship design. It's important for me to find some quiet time away from the church to work in a coffee shop where I have blocks of time uninterrupted by daily responsibilities to craft the sermon.

Hopefully that helps you get started, Matzu.

I'm honored that you thought of me.

Best,

Max

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